pre-modern state, as well as providing fish, a place for washing people and clothes, water for cooking, irrigation and drinking, and - in the Hindu tradition - the space for sacred ceremonies, especially cremations and the disposal of the ashes of the deceased. Thus, rivers were absolutely central to life in the Mughal Empire, and undoubtedly Shah Jahan intended to have his great mausoleum viewed as much from the river as from the gardens.



Looking south toward the Taj Mahal with the Yamuna River in the foreground

Of course, since the Mausoleum is perfectly symmetrical, the view from the River is identical to that of the garden. In some ways, it may be even more striking, because those approaching from the river arrive at a lower height than the visitors on foot. The Taj appears to loom over the Yamuna, as its marble terrace is built close to the riverfront and there is no perimeter wall to shield its bulk. Moreover, as there is nothing else on the bank for some distance, it is not crowded by other structures. As the primary artery of the empire, connecting the capital to far-flung territories, it would have been an impressive picture of imperial power for those traveling up to the capital, especially foreign dignitaries who arrived by sea to today's Calcutta and Bengal and then traveled up the Ganges.